18
UNIVERSITIES EXCLUSIVELY FOR **WOMEN**, UP FROM 11 IN 2014-15

19
OPEN UNIVERSITIES, OF WHICH 1 IS CENTRAL, 17 STATE, 1 PRIVATE

37
MINORITY-MANAGED UNIVERSITIES, 16 ARE MUSLIM, 10 CHRISTIAN, 5 JAIN, 3 SIKH

151
AFFILIATING UNIVERSITIES HAVE **100** OR MORE COLLEGES

21
UNIVERSITIES HAVE **500** OR MORE COLLEGES

a new laboratory without revealing whether students regularly use it. It may announce international collaborations that produce little faculty or student exchange.

A ranking must also guard against becoming a closed club in which established institutions repeatedly confirm their established reputations. That is why the introduction of the Most Improved Universities category is significant. By measuring the percentage change in an institution's relative position between the 2022 and 2026 rankings, it draws attention to momentum rather than inherited prestige.

For students, this can be almost as valuable as knowing which institution stands first. A university that is consistently improving its faculty, research, infrastructure and student outcomes may offer a more dynamic environment than one relying largely on its historical reputation. For university leaders, the category makes improvement visible and demonstrates that rankings need not merely reward those already at the top but create incentives for institutions further down the table.

The strongest insights from this year's survey emerge not from the names of the category leaders alone but from the choices those institutions are making. At the University of Delhi, the rise in global rankings has been accompanied by a broader definition of academic achievement. Doctoral research can now result not only in a thesis or journal article but also in a patent, prototype or startup.

Symbiosis International offers another model. Founded to assist international students in Pune, it now has

AS THE JANTAR MANTAR PROTESTS DEMONSTRATED, EXPANSION WITHOUT CREDIBILITY WON'T SATISFY INDIA'S YOUNG

45 institutes and 105 programmes, serving about 70,000 students from more than 85 countries. Its MBA in Innovation and Entrepreneurship, which offers no conventional placements, receives 12,000 applications for 60 seats. The demand shows that many students are willing to choose enterprise creation over a guaranteed recruitment pipeline.

At AIIMS Delhi, the educational advantage lies not only in its long-standing dominance of medical rankings but also in the scale and complexity of its clinical work. Residents treat rare and difficult diseases in an intensive tertiary-care environment, making clinical exposure central to their education.

At IIT Delhi, academic excellence is being recast around flexibility, interdisciplinary learning and practical problem-solving. Its redesigned programmes allow students to combine courses across departments, while artificial intelligence and sustainability are being embedded across disciplines.

At the National Law School of India University, expansion is being matched by investments in academic capacity, residential infrastructure and inclusion. With 118 faculty members and 1,631 students as of June 2026, it is completing two academic blocks and will build hostels for nearly 3,000 students by 2028. It is also piloting AI-assisted tutoring and launching the Women's Inclusion and Leadership in Law initiative. The latter addresses a stark imbalance: women make up 32 per cent of law graduates but only 15 per cent of the 1.8 million lawyers admitted to practice.

These initiatives across top universities prove that excellence is built around flexibility, exposure, inclusion, research and application. For, as the protests at Jantar Mantar have demonstrated, expansion without credibility will not satisfy India's young. The institutions recognised in the Best Universities Survey demonstrate that decline is not inevitable and that the country already has different pathways to excellence. The purpose of the survey is to make those pathways visible, giving students and parents better information, rewarding institutions that perform well and challenging others to raise their standards. ■